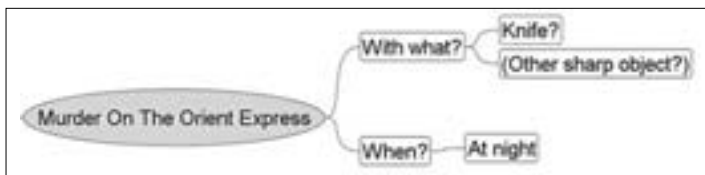


9.2.1 Nodes

Everything's about ~nodes~ in FreeMind. When you create a new mind map, it start with a central node (your theme) and then branches into child nodes, their children nodes and so on. The



A basic mind map with a few nodes

branches that join these nodes are called ~edges~. Nodes can contain as much text as you'd like, limited only by how readable you want your mind map to be. Typically, though, you're not supposed to use full sentences in your mind maps - the experts advise using just words and phrases to convey meaning.

Click on the central node to change the title - "New Mindmap" is hardly what you're going to call it, is it? Use the [Insert] key to start creating new nodes. To create multiple nodes at the same level of hierarchy, hit [Enter]. You can use the arrow keys to move around the mind map, creating or deleting nodes (with the [Delete] key, naturally) as you go along. Use [F2] to change the content of any node - this is much like Excel. You should quickly get used to this style of keyboard navigation - you'll find it a lot easier to work when you don't have to worry about using the mouse every now and then. Refer to the end of this chapter for a full list of FreeMind's keyboard shortcuts.

Now that we've completed the basic act of creating and editing nodes, let's see what else we can do with them.

9.2.2 Formatting Nodes

While highly functional, your basic mind map is hardly visually appealing. Not that it needs to be pretty just for the sake of it, but good mind maps always have visual cues that, for whatever reason, highlight items within the map. It could be a big red sign